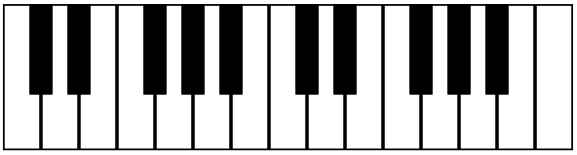
Read at Sight

A graded sight-reading course for piano

Volume 4 - Patterns and Keys



Middle C

Chords in both hands, high and low notes, syncopation and sixteenths, keys with three sharps or flats, and music that changes key.

Exercises generated to graded rules; pieces are original or public domain.

How to use this book

What is new in Volume 4

Both hands now play chords, and the accompaniment falls into patterns you learn to read at a glance: held chords, oom-pah and waltz basses, chorales and after-beat chords. You will read ledger lines far above and below the staves, syncopated rhythms and sixteenth notes, the keys of A major, E-flat major, F-sharp minor and C minor, and music that moves into a new key. 2/4 time joins 3/4, 4/4 and 6/8. Start this book when you can read Volume 3 music: broken-chord and Alberti basses, 6/8, keys with two sharps or flats, and two independent voices.

The five rules

1. Never stop: keep the beat going, even after a wrong note. 2. Count out loud and use a metronome at the speed shown. 3. Keep your eyes on the music, not your hands. 4. Read the shape: up, down, or the same, and by how much. 5. Play each exercise once, tick its box, and move on. Come back only after a few weeks.

Before every exercise: 10 seconds

Check the clef and time signature. Find the first note and its finger number. Scan for the highest and lowest note, and for any bar that repeats an earlier one. Then count one bar in and play.

How each unit is laid out

A unit opens with what is new, a keyboard picture of the hand position, and reading tips. Then come Parts A, B and C, which grow slightly harder. Pieces come next, and the unit ends with a checkpoint that tells you when to move on.

A daily routine (15-20 minutes)

Warm up by playing the five notes of the hand position up and down, saying their names (2 minutes). Read 6-10 new exercises, one pass each (10 minutes). Play one piece, aiming for steady and musical (5 minutes).

Contents

Each unit adds exactly one new idea to everything before it.

Unit 1 Block Chords 4
The left hand plays I, IV and V7 as three-note chords: held, oom-pah and waltz

Unit 2 Chords in Both Hands
Right-hand three-note chords; 2/4 time

Unit 3 High Notes
Ledger lines above the treble staff, up to D6; the hand moves up an octave

Unit 4 Low Notes and the Middle
Ledger lines below the bass staff, down to C2; both hands near middle C

Unit 5 Syncopation
Notes that start between the beats: ties over the beat and the bar line, accents

Unit 6 Sixteenth Notes
Four sixteenths, an eighth and two sixteenths, the dotted eighth and sixteenth

Unit 7 Three Sharps and Three Flats
A major, E-flat major, F-sharp minor and C minor

Unit 8 Changing Key
A new key in the middle of a piece, with a new key signature or with accidentals; review

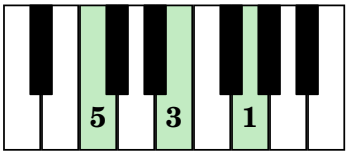
Unit 1

Block Chords

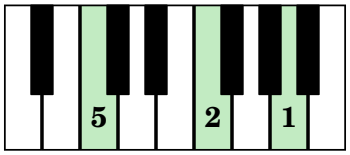
New: The left hand plays I, IV and V7 as three-note chords: held, oom-pah and waltz

In Volume 3 the left hand played its chords one note at a time. Now it plays them as block chords, all three notes together. A block chord is read as one shape, not three notes: you already know the shapes, so the left hand becomes a quick glance while your eyes stay on the tune.

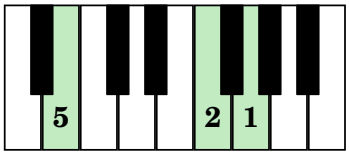
C major: left-hand chord shapes



I = C

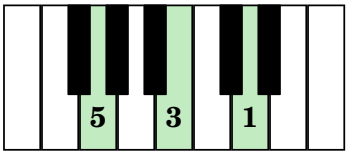


IV = F

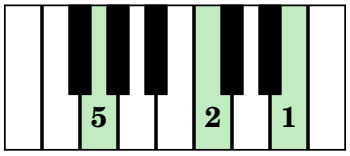


V7 = G7

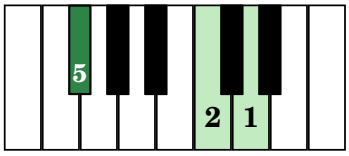
G major: left-hand chord shapes



I = G

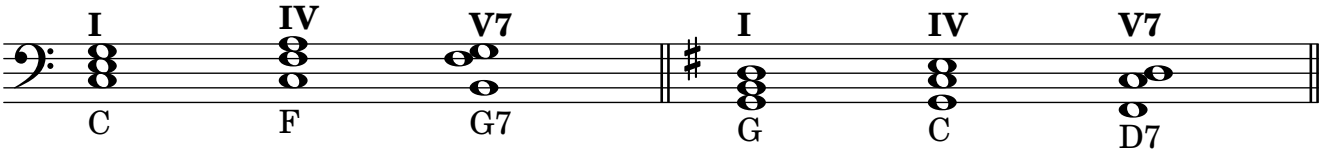


IV = C



V7 = D7

The same shapes on the staff



What is new

Block chords

Three notes stacked on the staff and played together: I is C-E-G (fingers 5 3 1), IV is C-F-A and V7 is B-F-G (both 5 2 1). Drop the hand onto all three keys at once.

Oom-pah

In 4/4 the left hand plays the bottom note of the shape on beats 1 and 3 (the 'oom') and the upper two notes together on beats 2 and 4 (the 'pah').

Waltz bass

In 3/4: the bottom note on beat 1, then the upper two notes on beats 2 and 3. Oom-pah-pah.

Finger numbers in chords

When a new shape starts, its finger numbers are printed next to the notes: 5 on the bottom note, 1 on the top.

Reading tips

1. Before you play, find each new chord shape in the left hand and name it: I, IV or V7.

2. Keep the 'pah' chords light and short. The 'oom' notes carry the bass line.

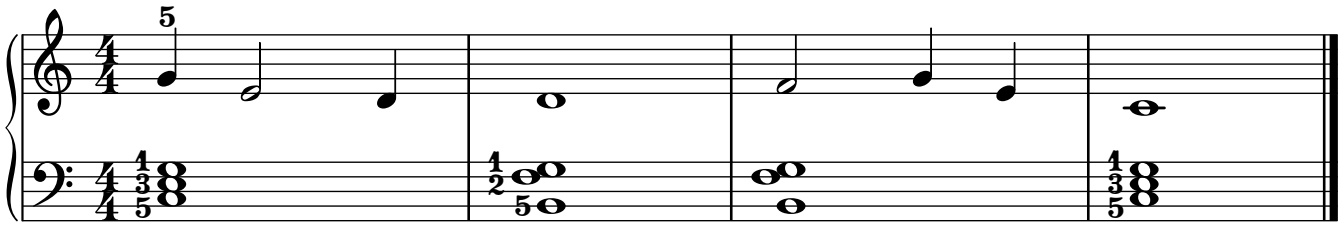
3. The first note of each bar in the right hand belongs to the left hand's chord: check that they fit.

Part A: Held chords under a tune

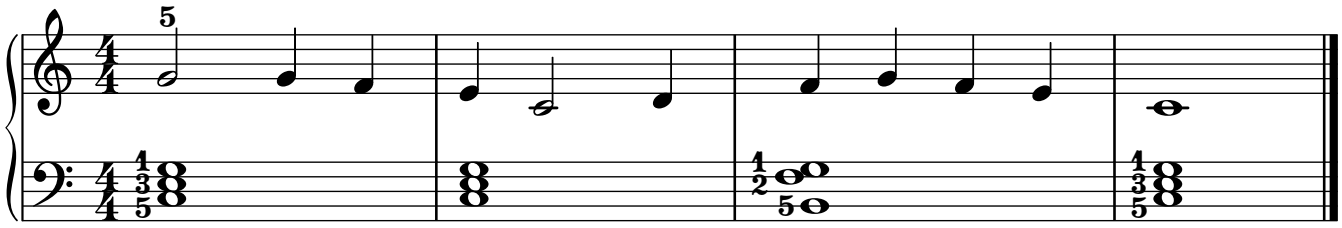
♩ = 60

C major. The left hand holds one chord for each bar.
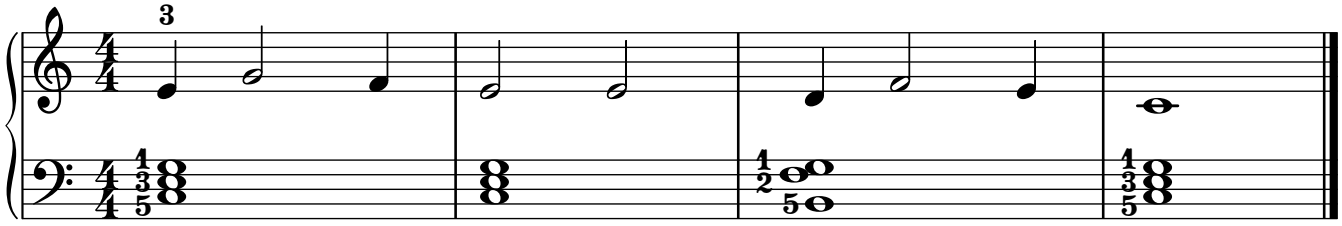
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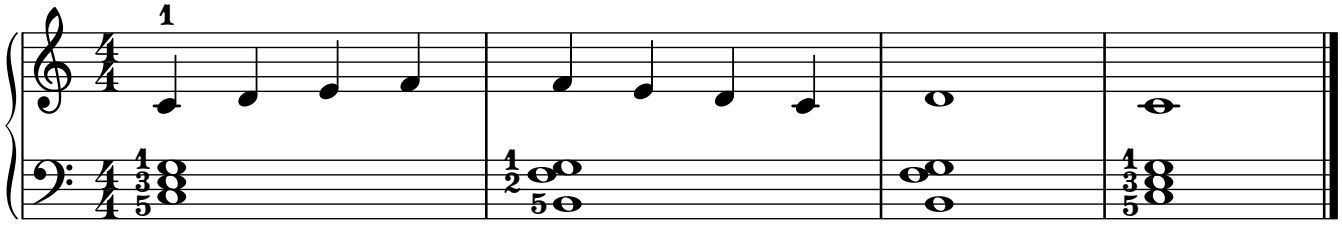
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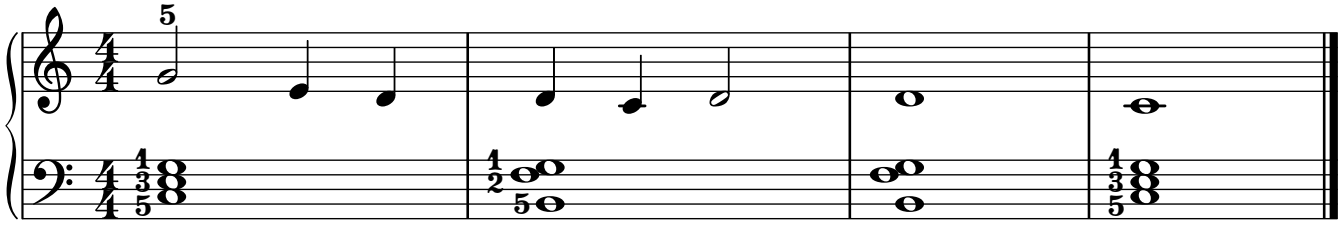
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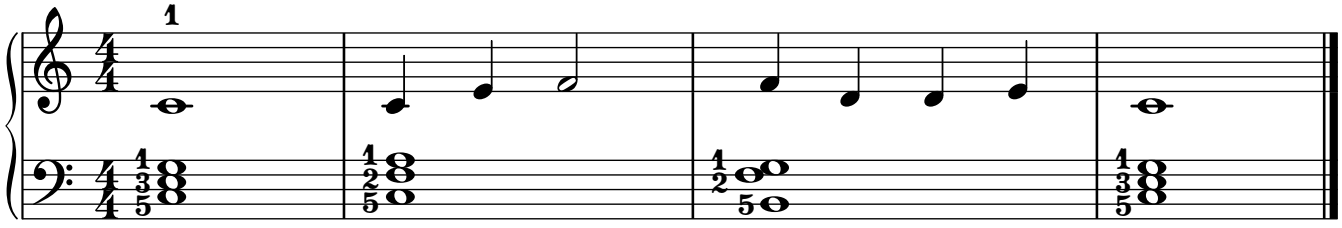


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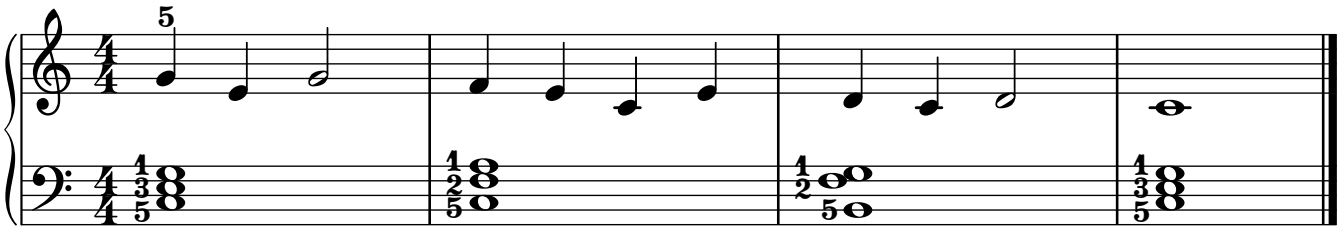
☐ **1.5**
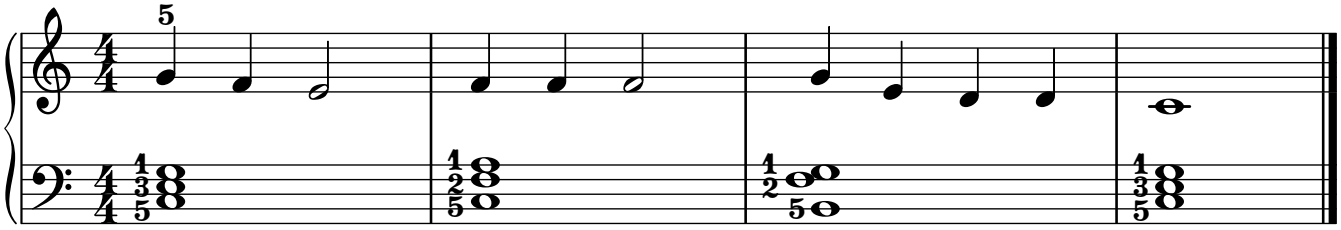


☐ **1.6**



☐ **1.7**
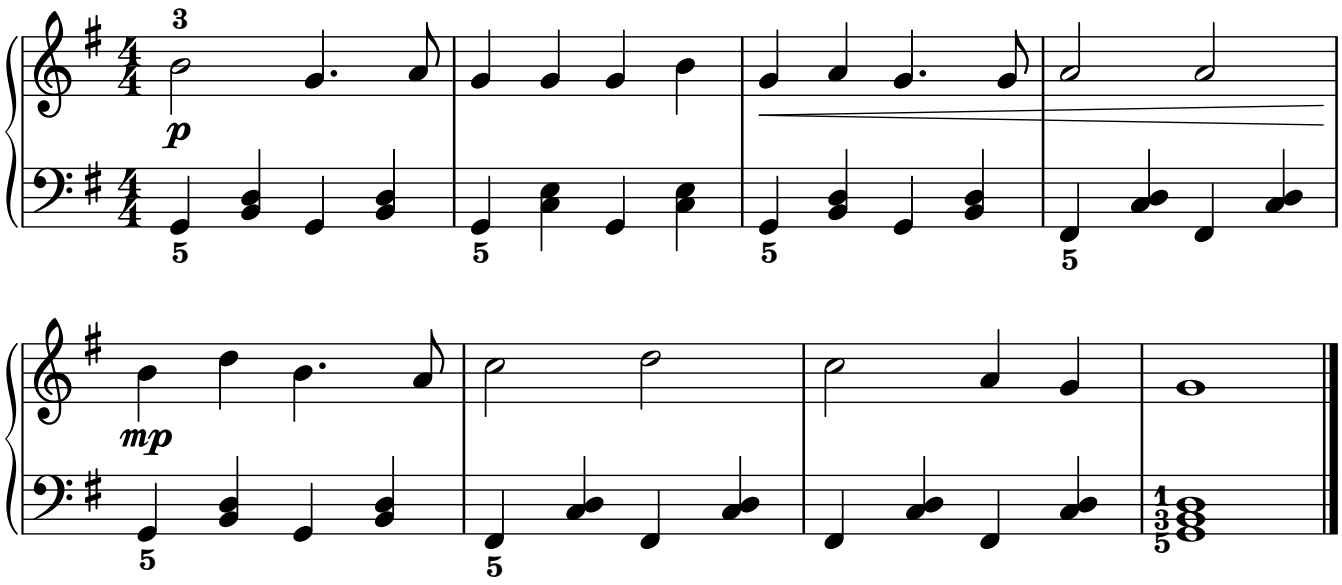


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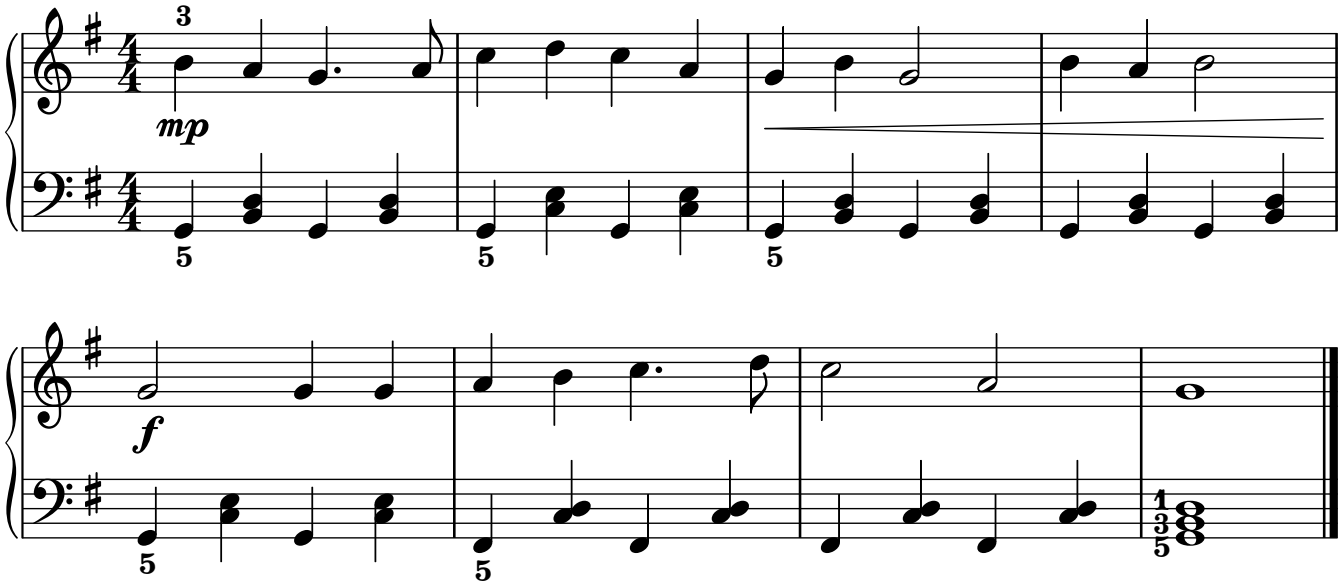


Part B: Oom-pah in G major ♩ = 72

G major with an oom-pah bass: bottom note, then the upper two notes together.
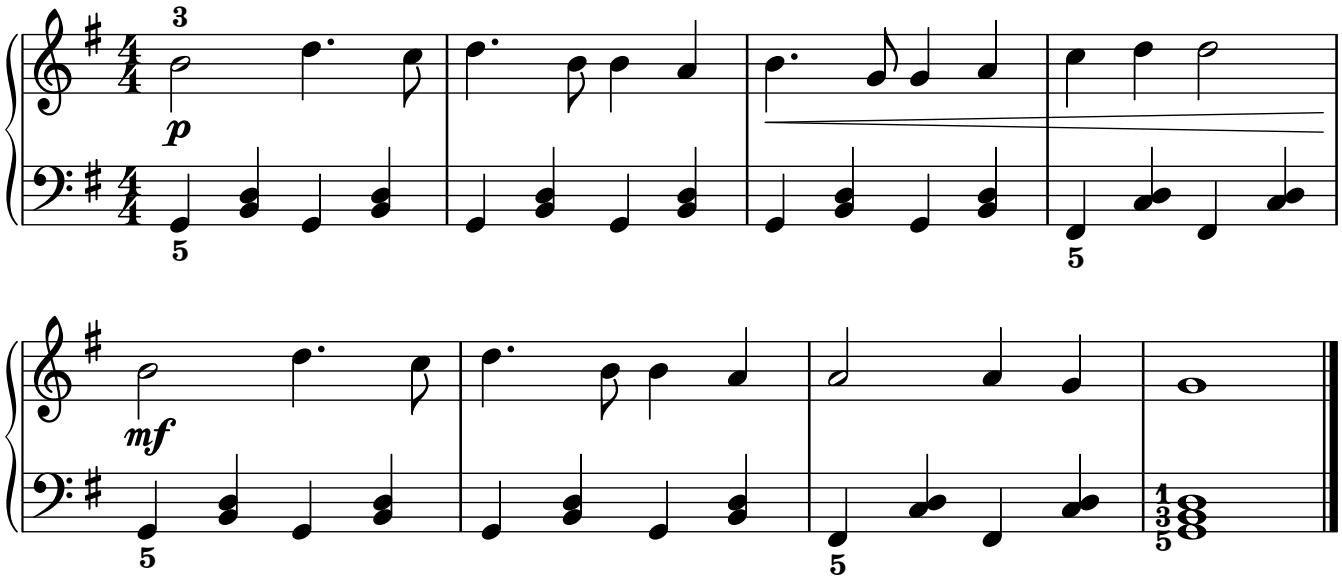
☐ **1.9**



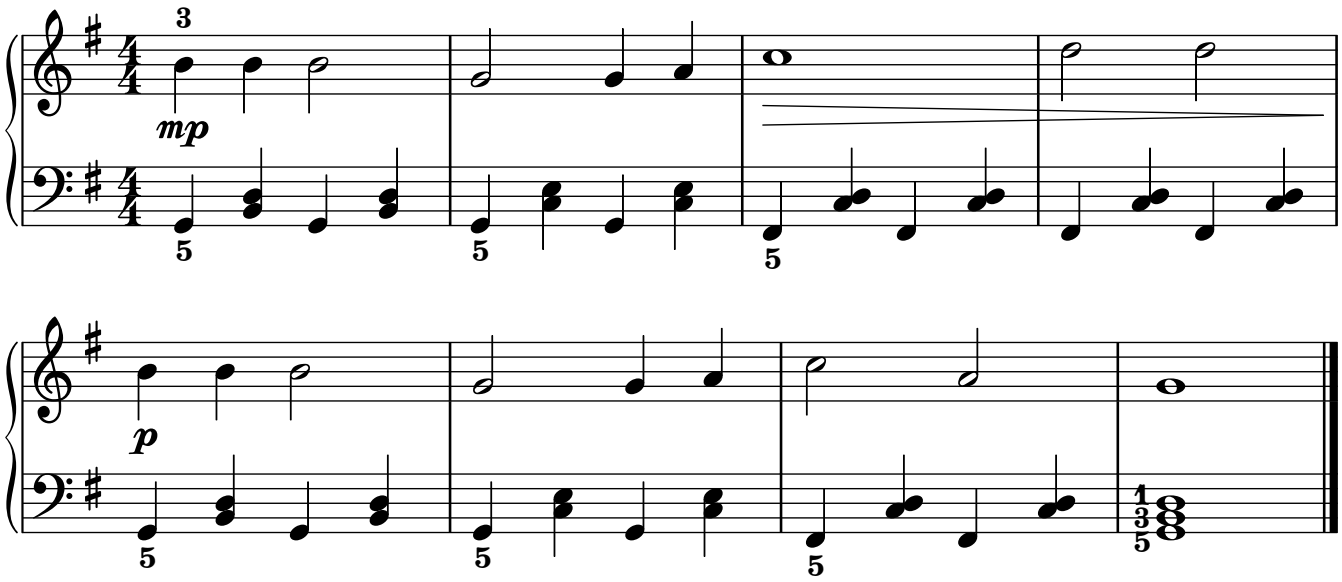
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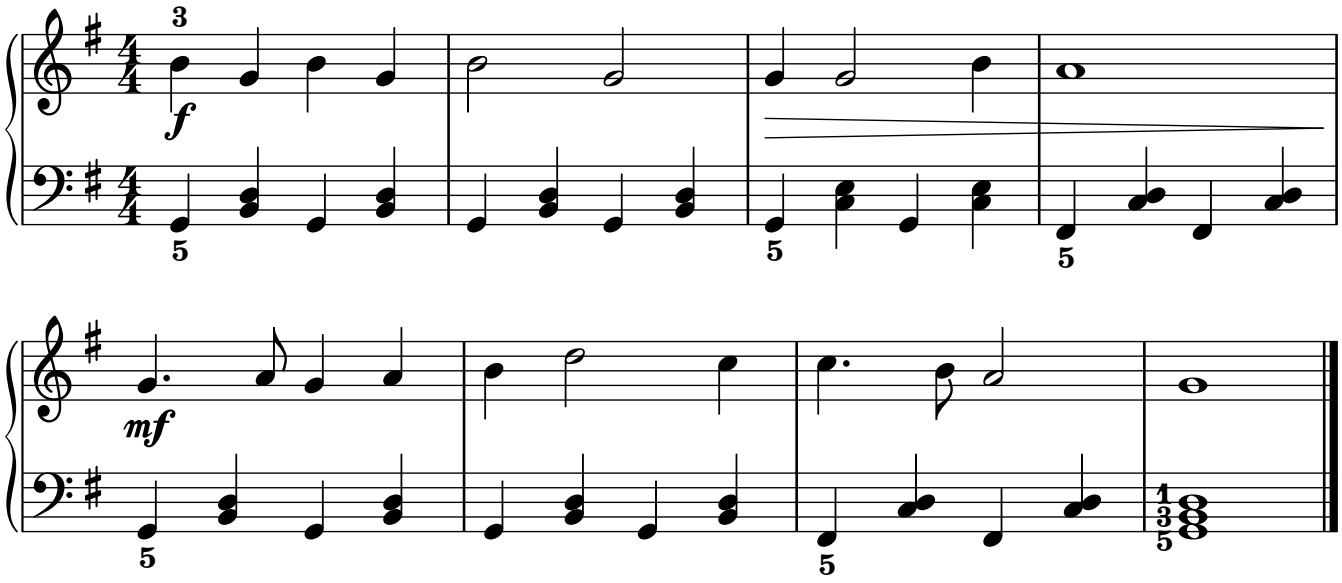


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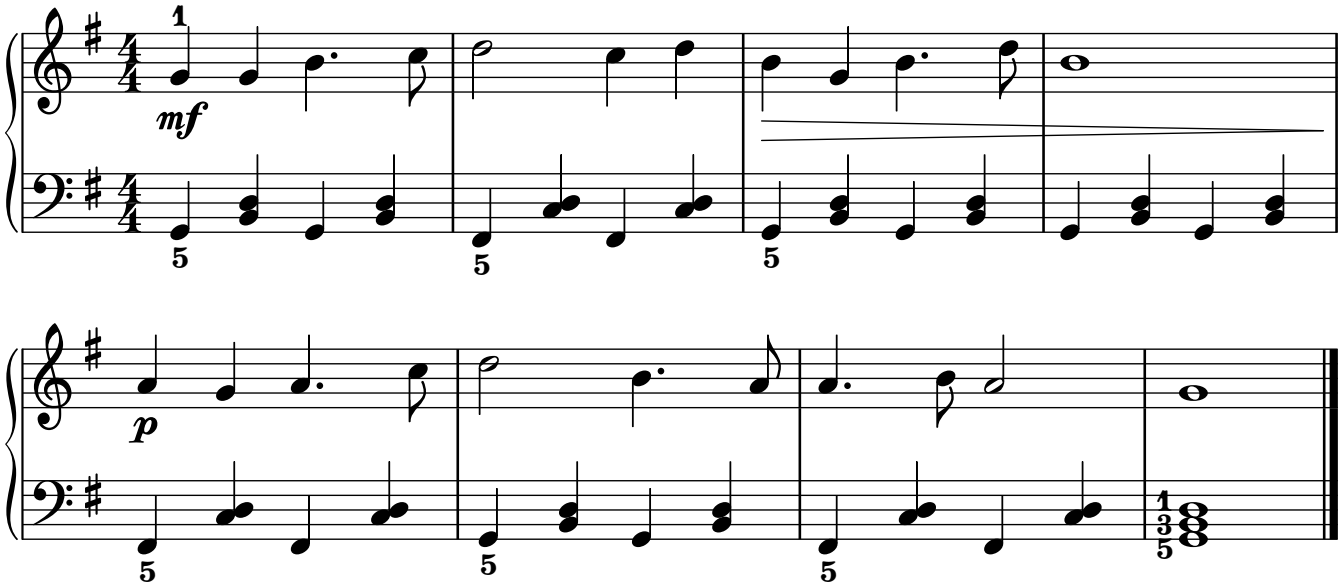
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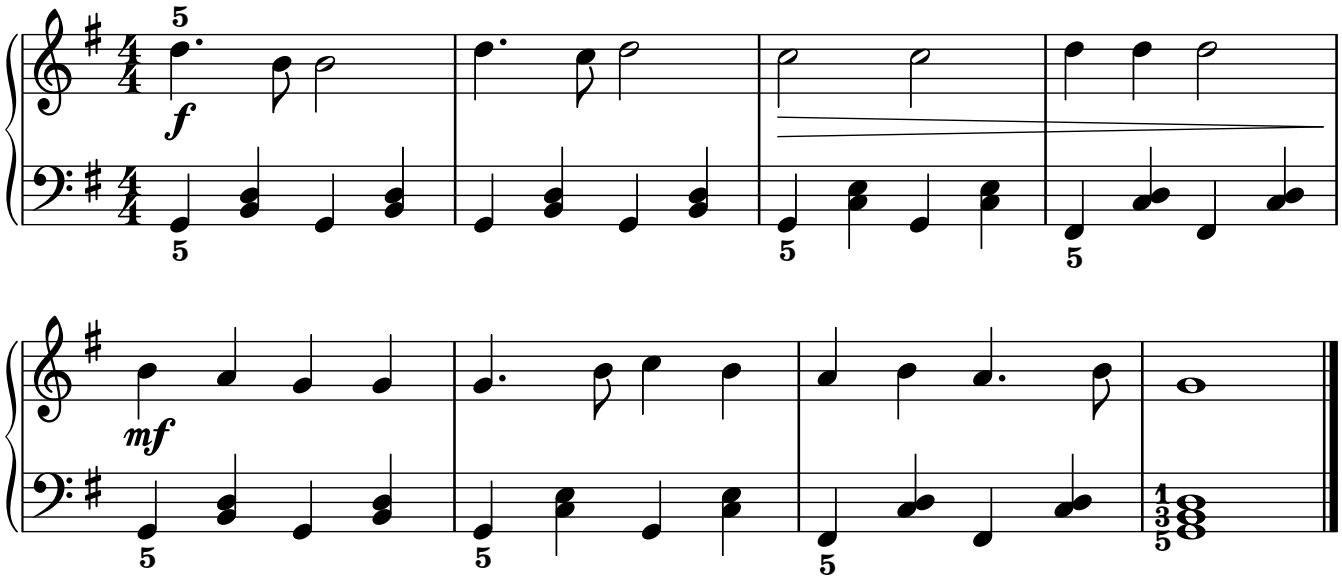
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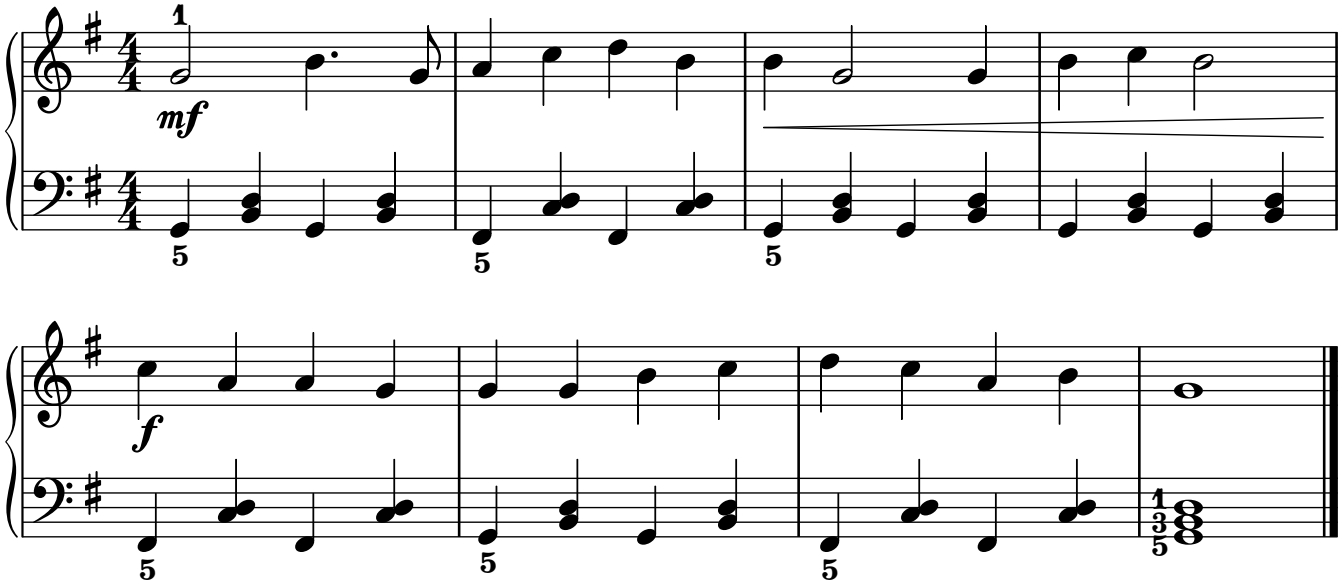
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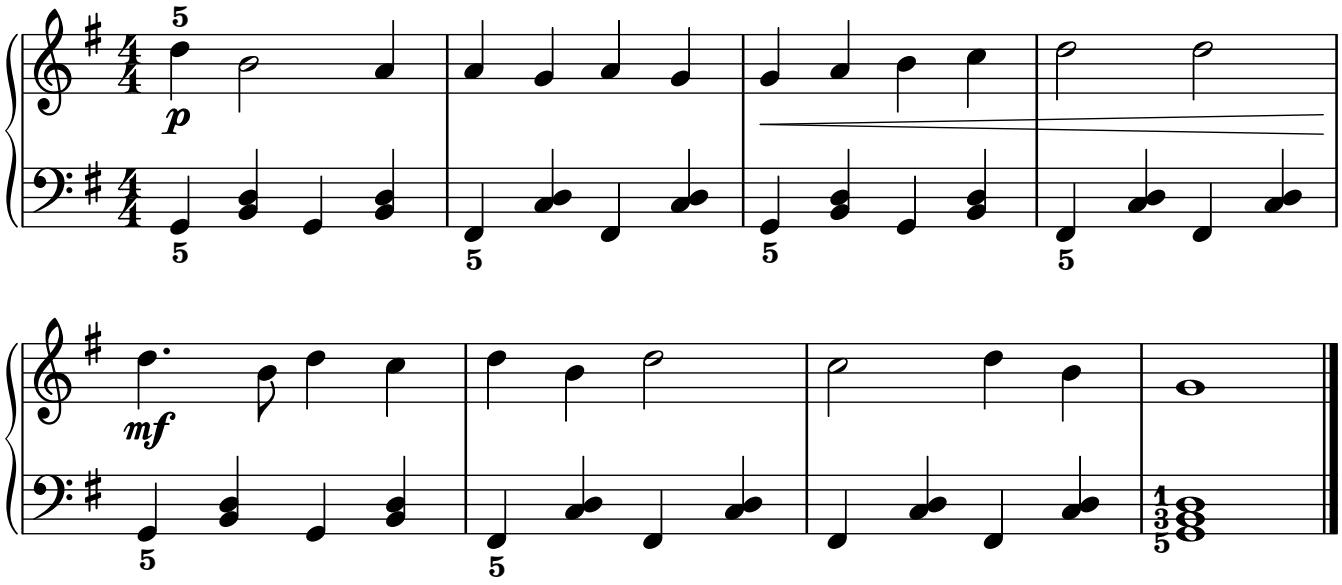
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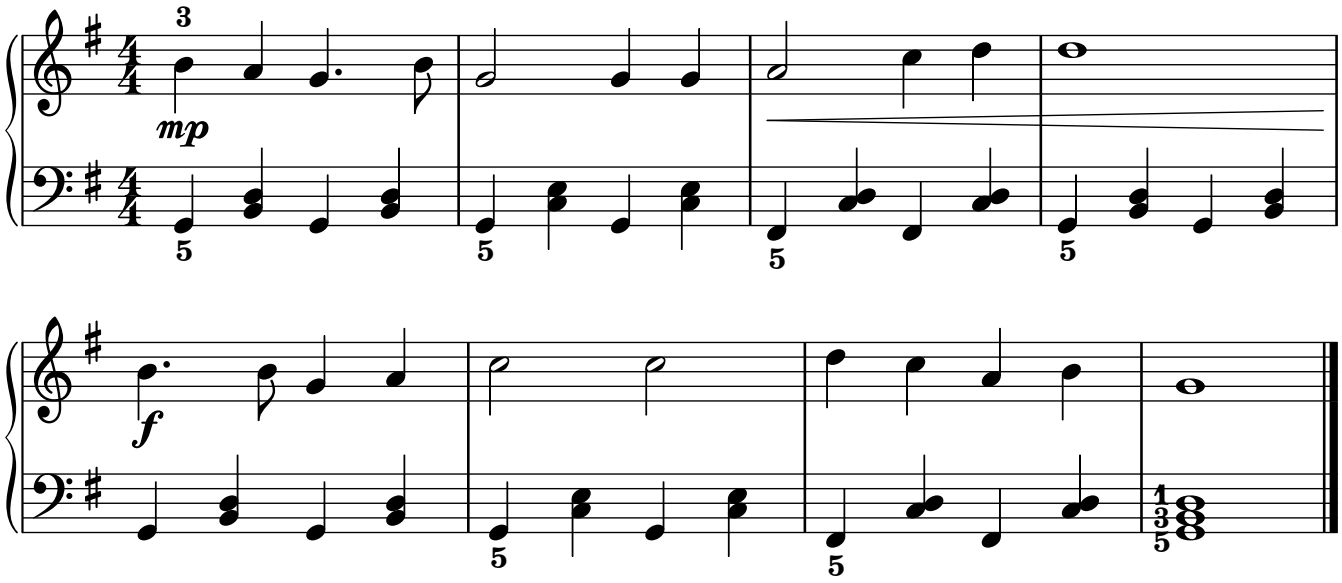
1.16



1.17



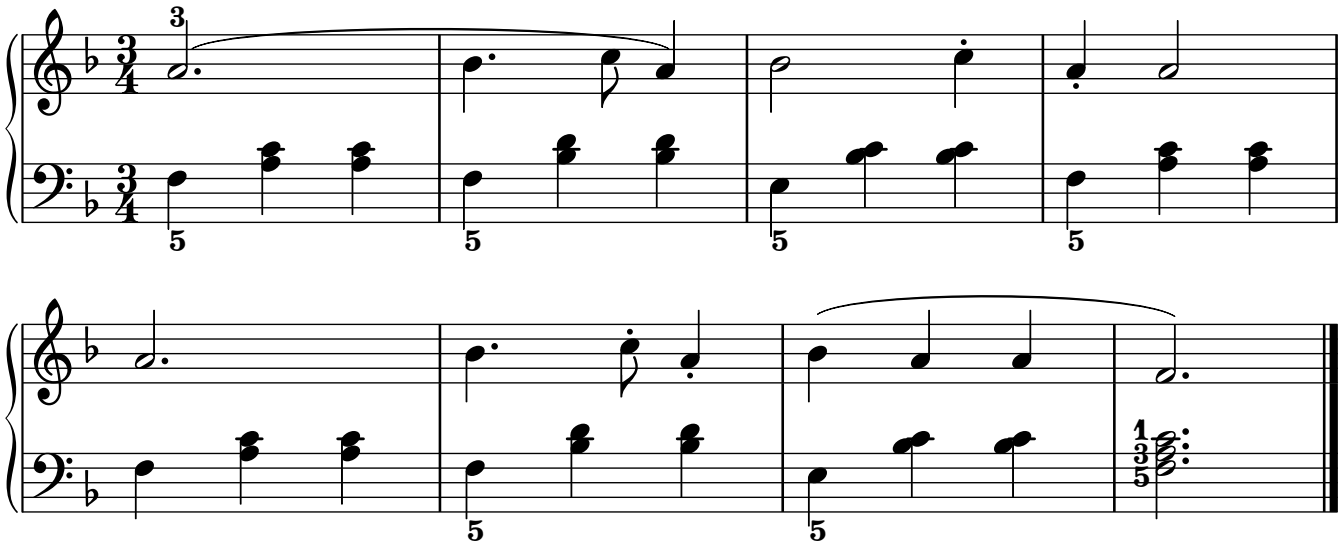
1.18



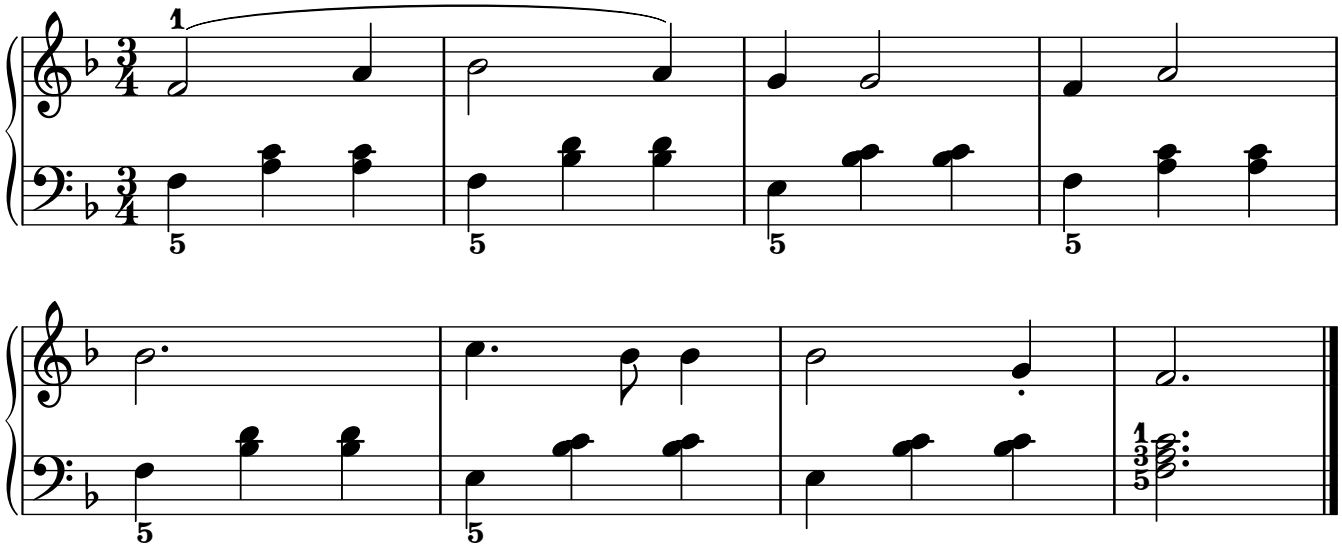
Part C: Waltz bass in F major ♩ = 84

F major waltzes: oom-pah-pah.

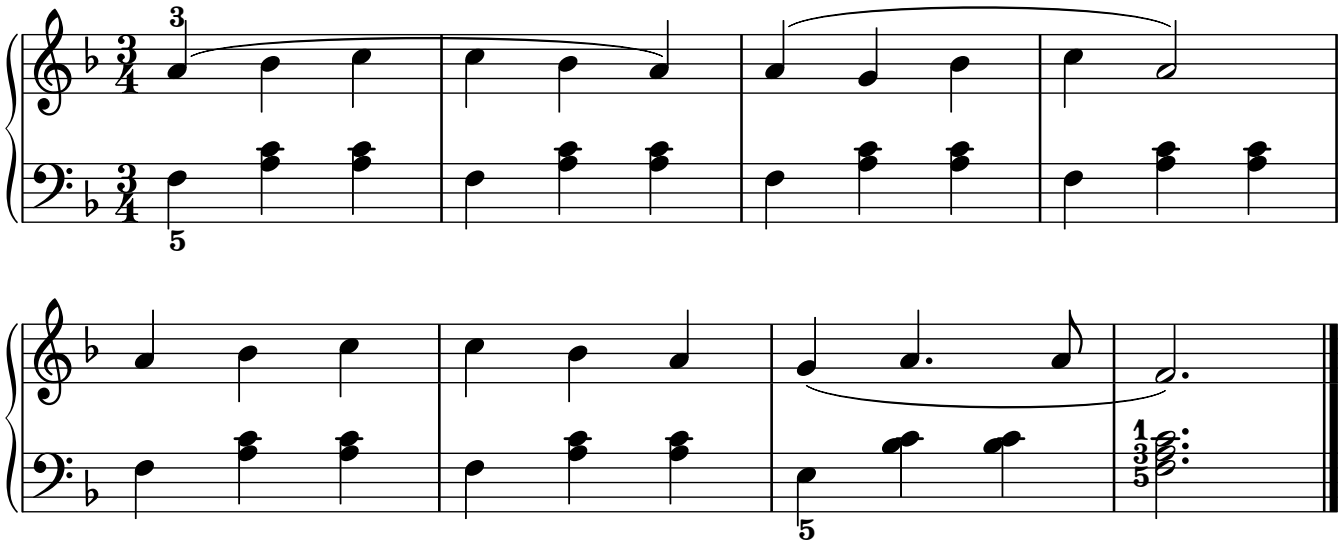
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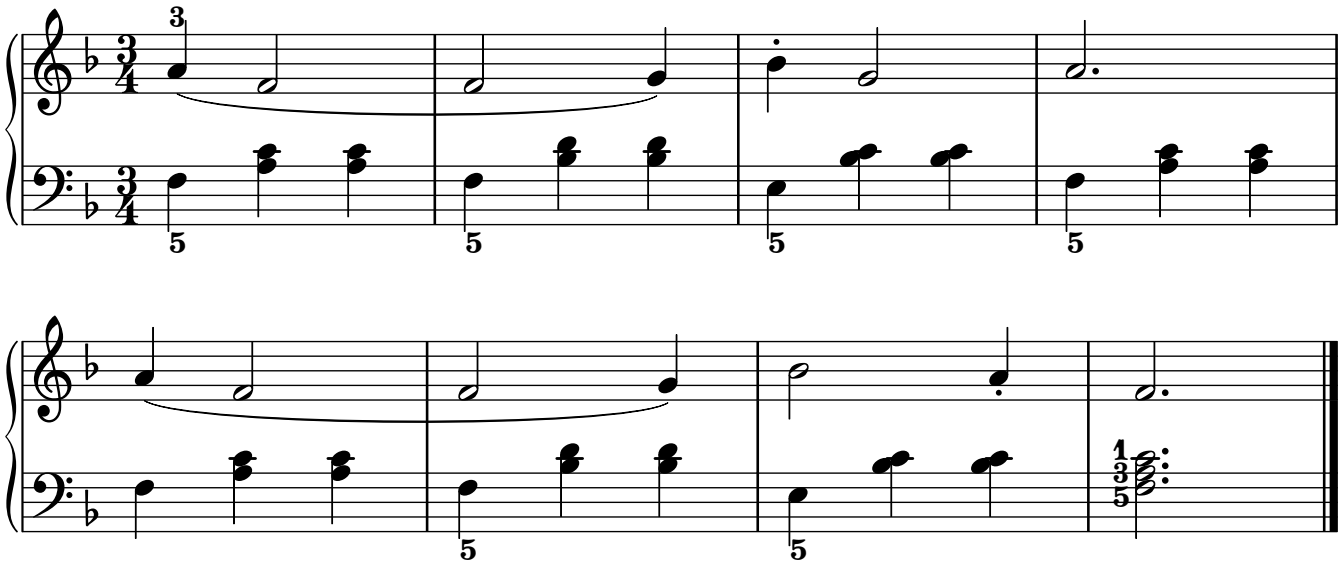
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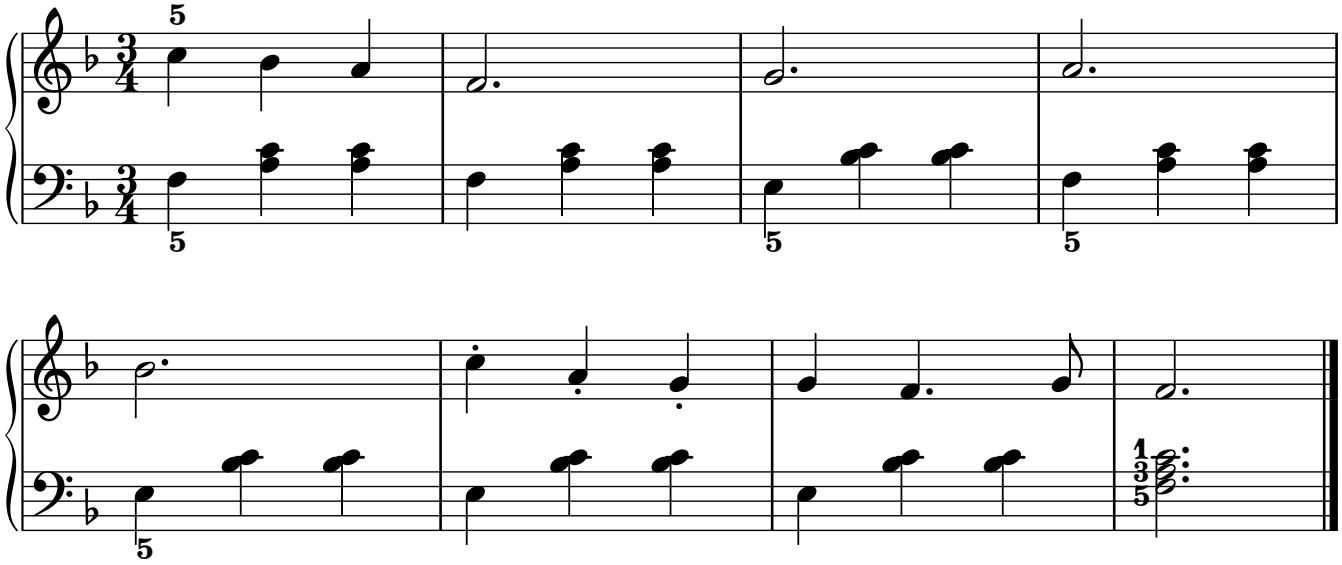
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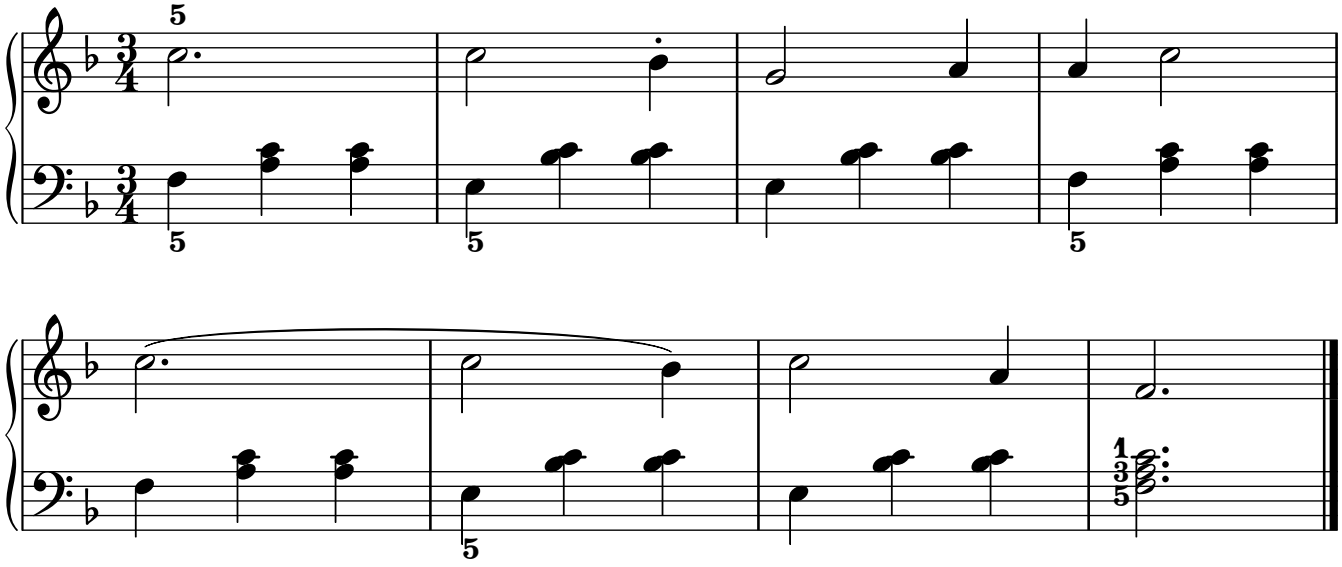
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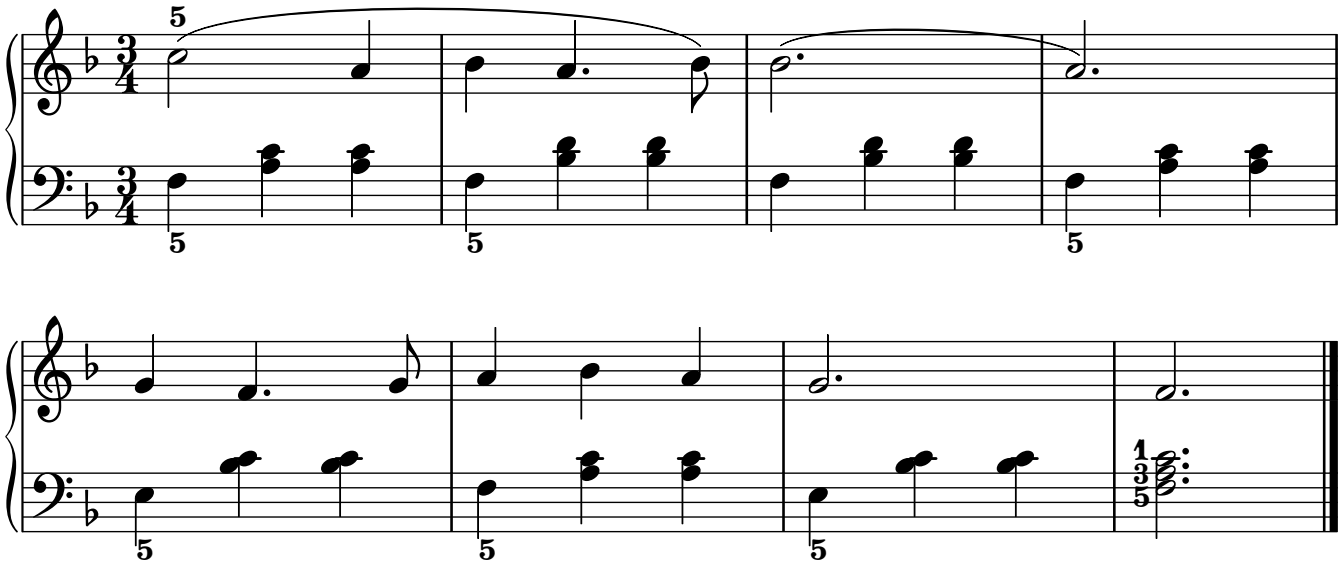
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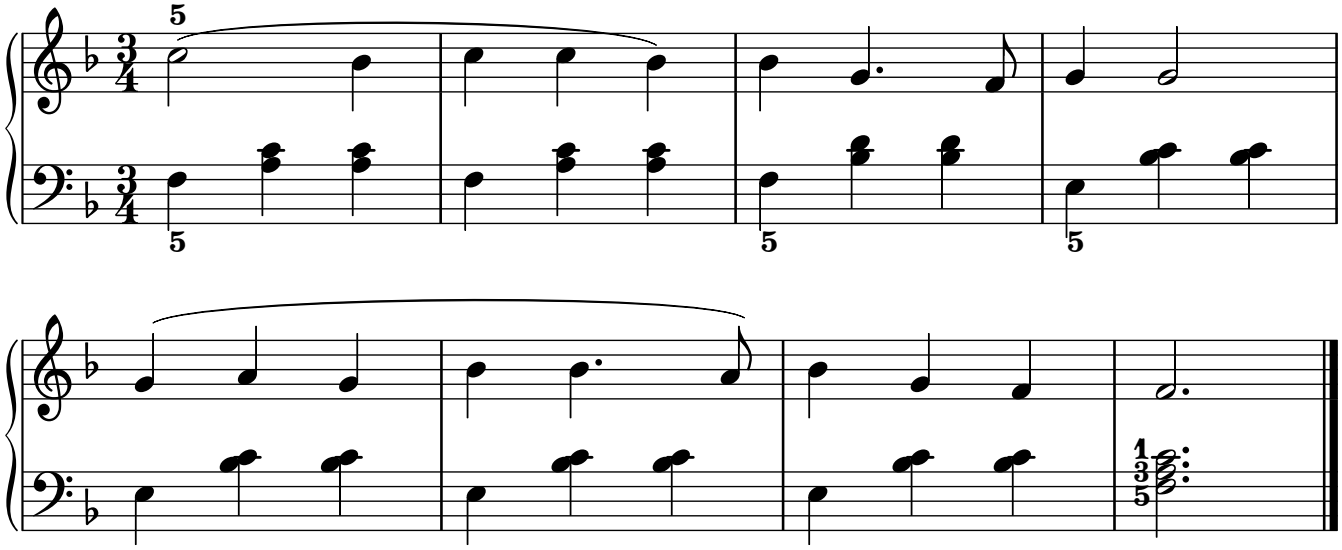
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1.25



1.26

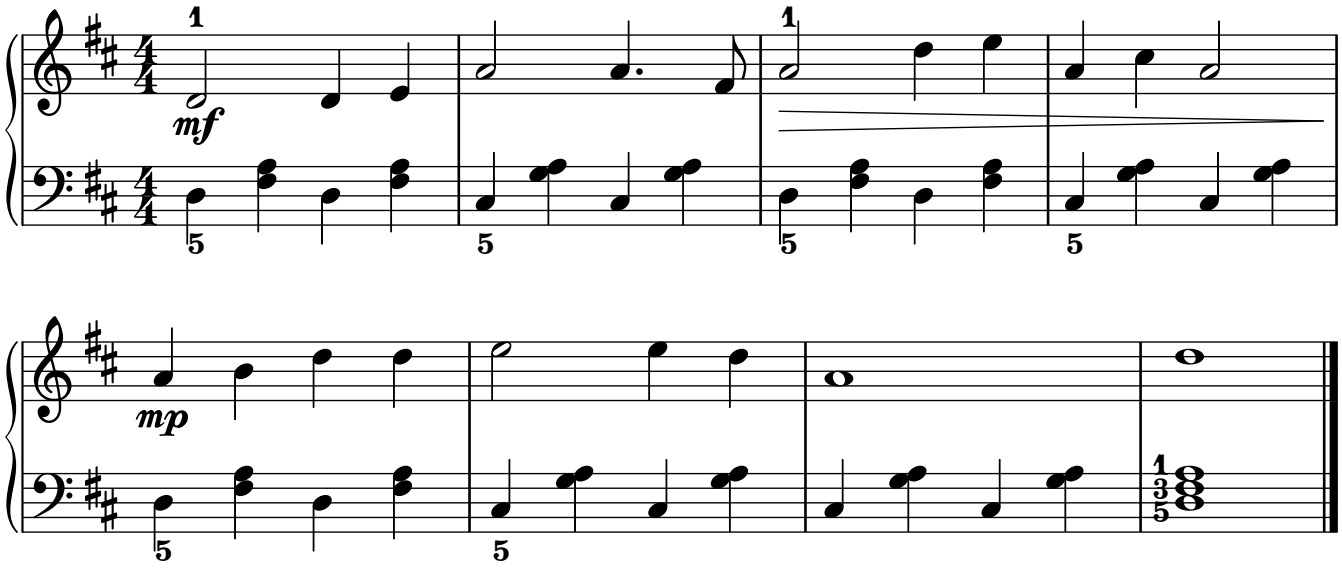


Part D: D major, the right hand on the move
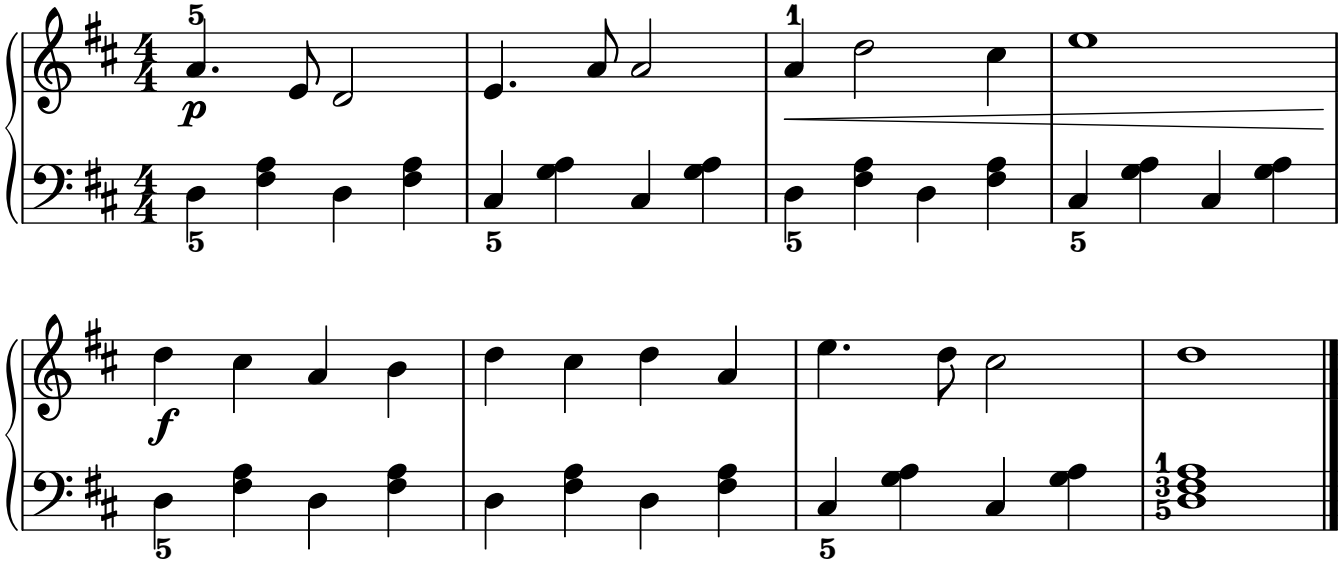
♩ = 72

D major oom-pah. The right hand moves between D position and A position.
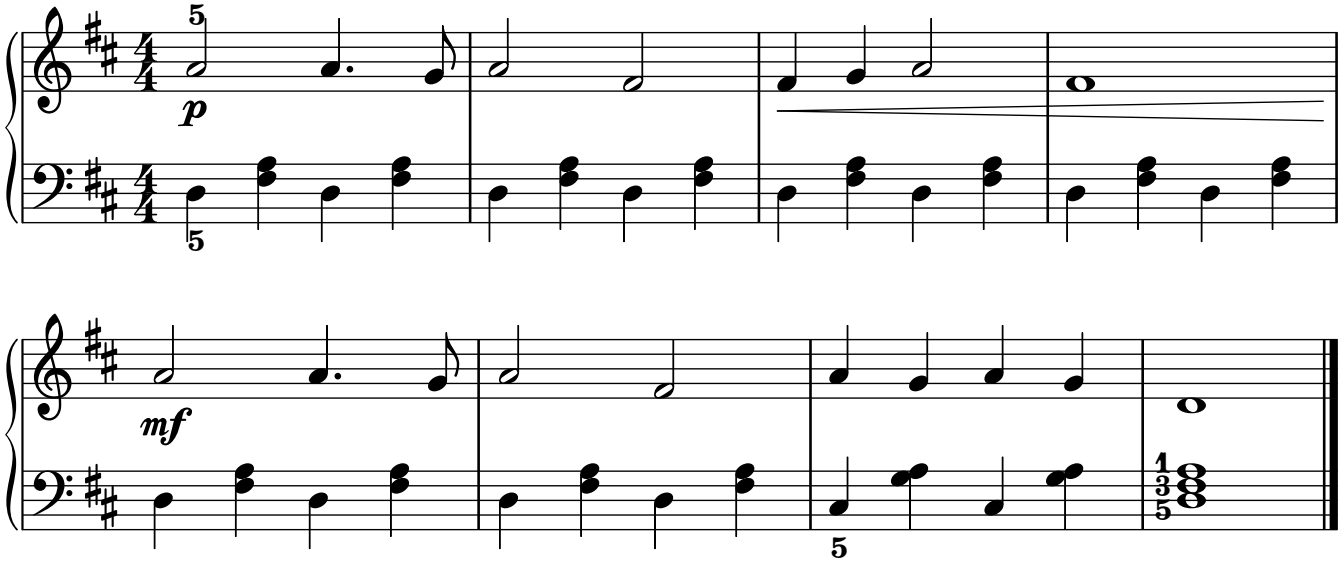
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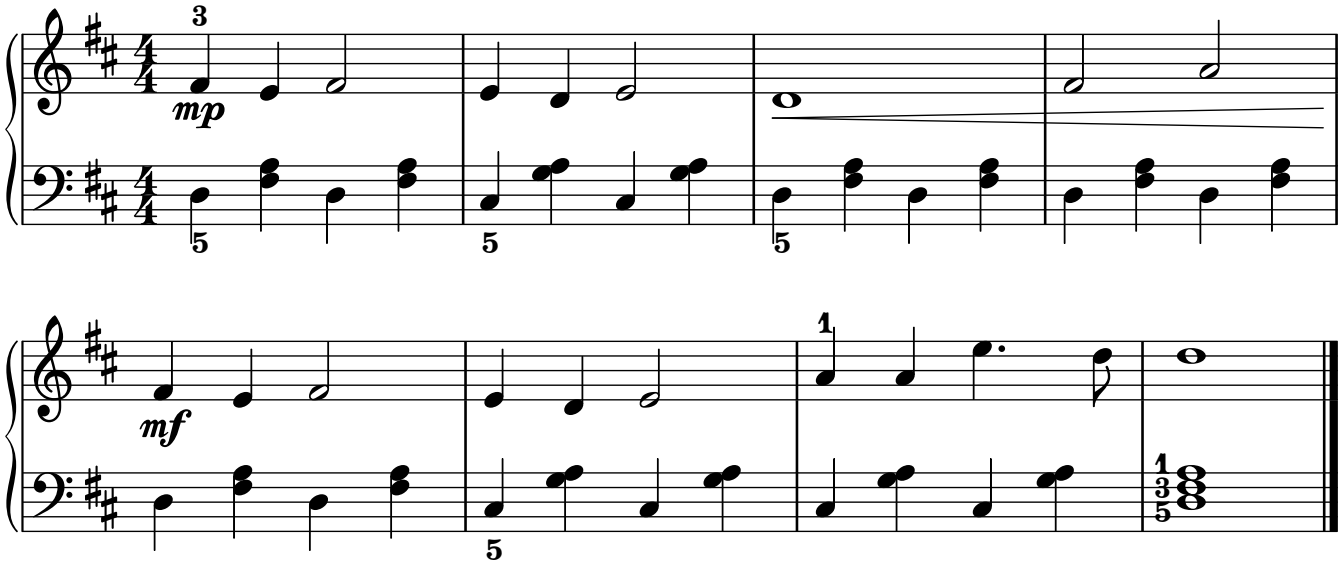
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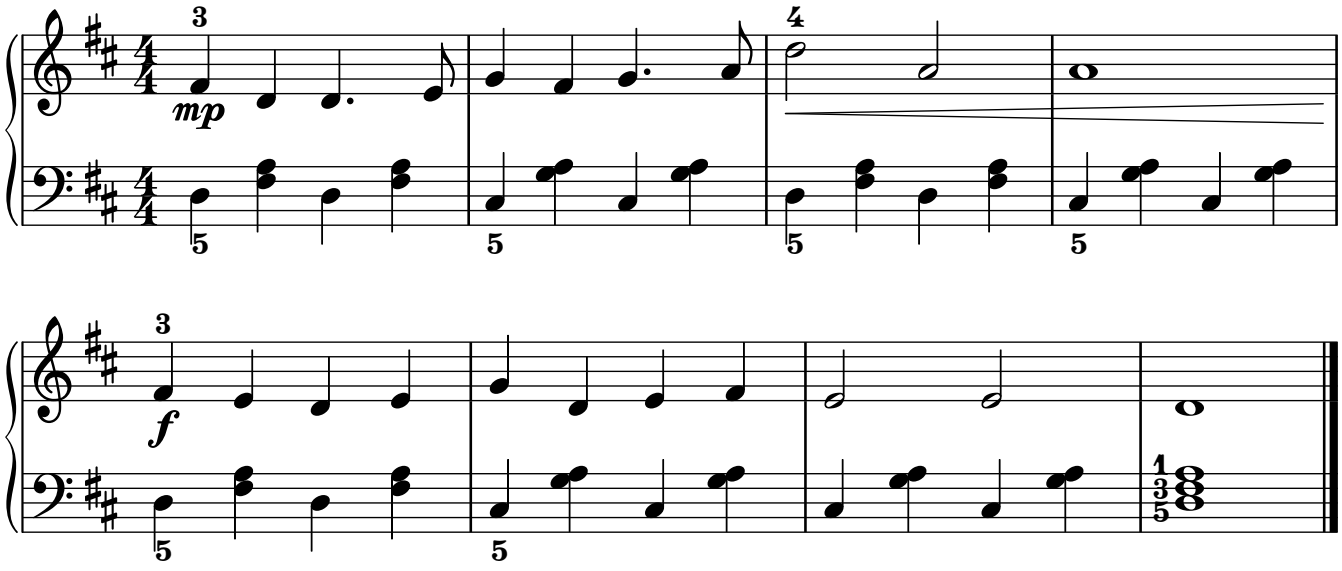


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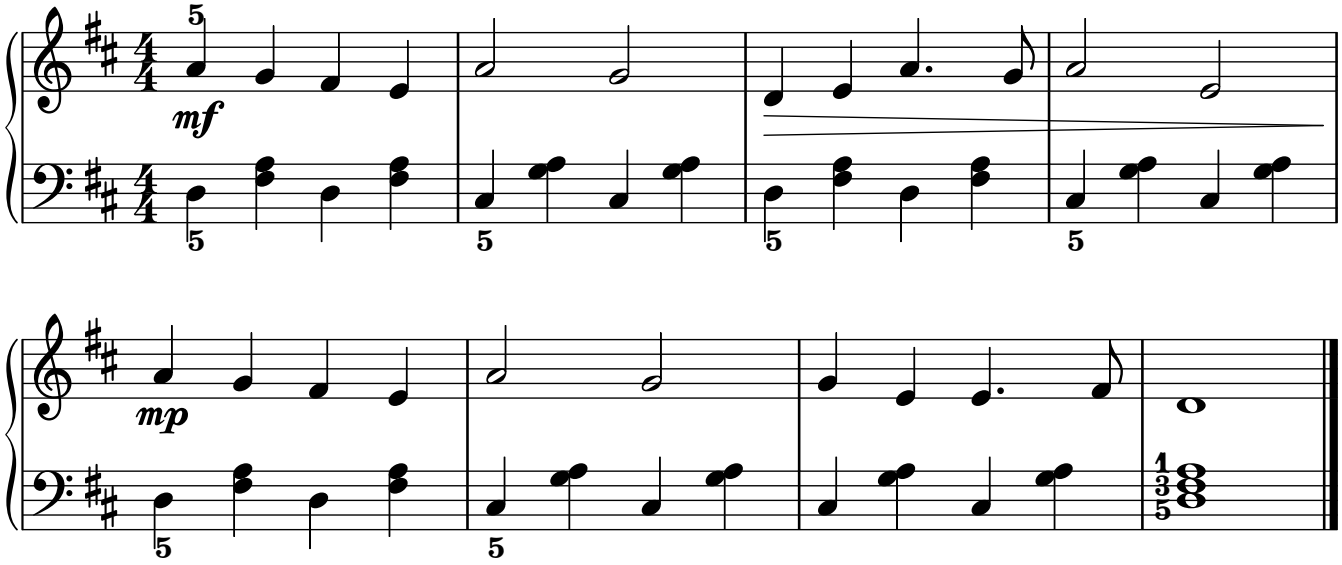
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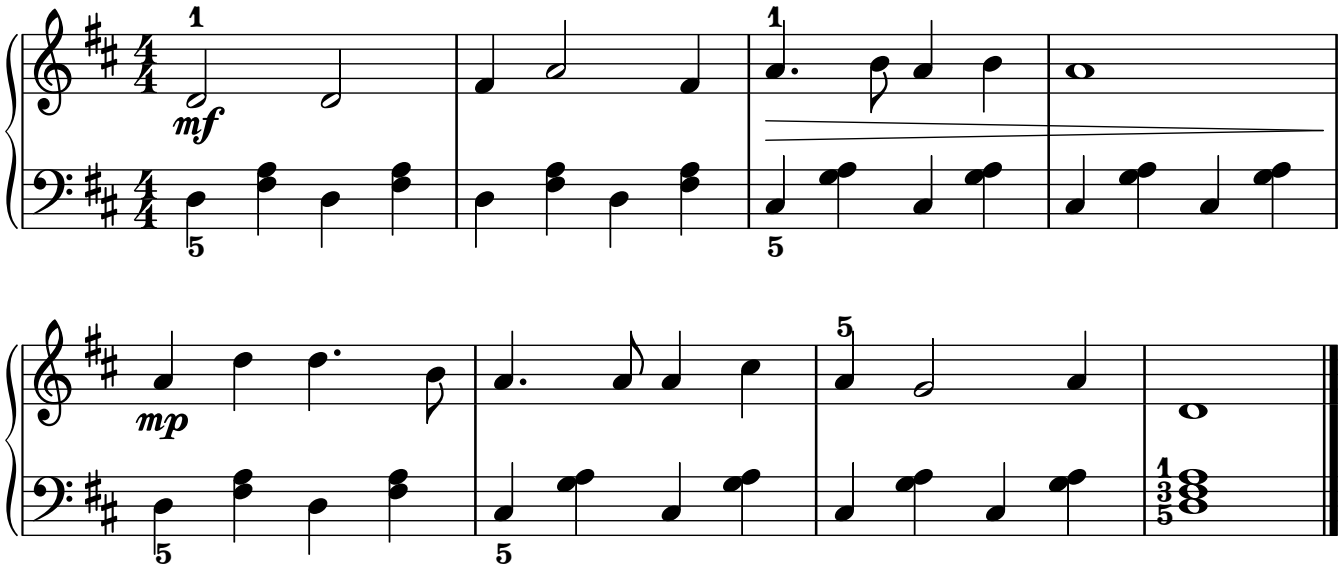
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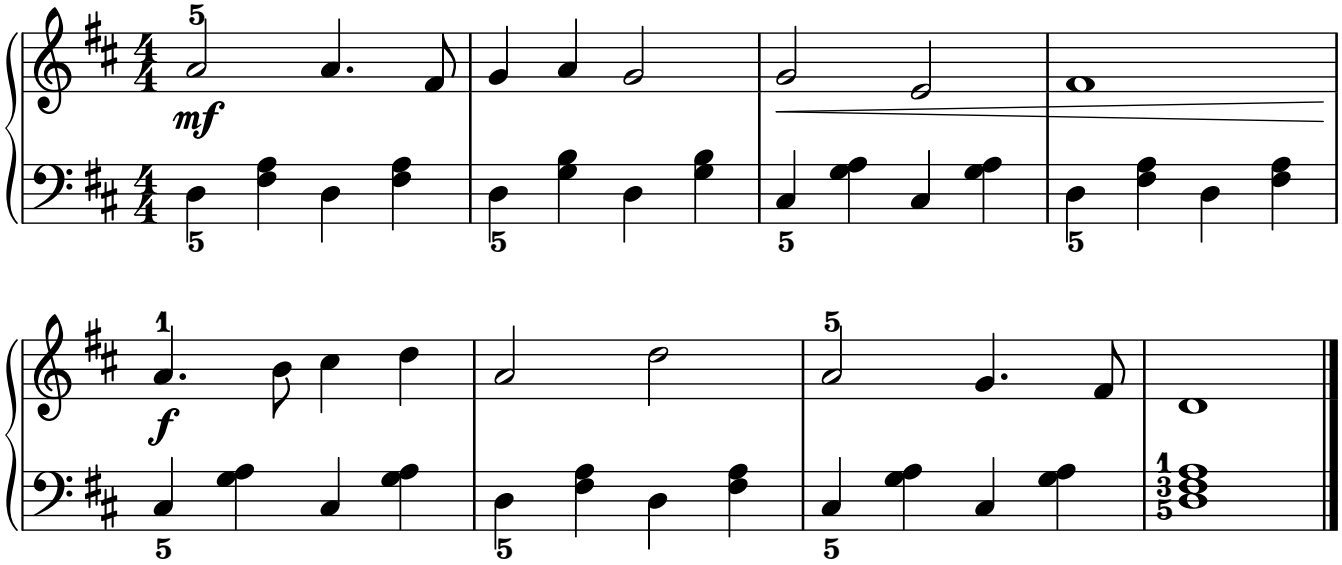


☐ **1.32**



☐ **1.33**



☐ **1.34**



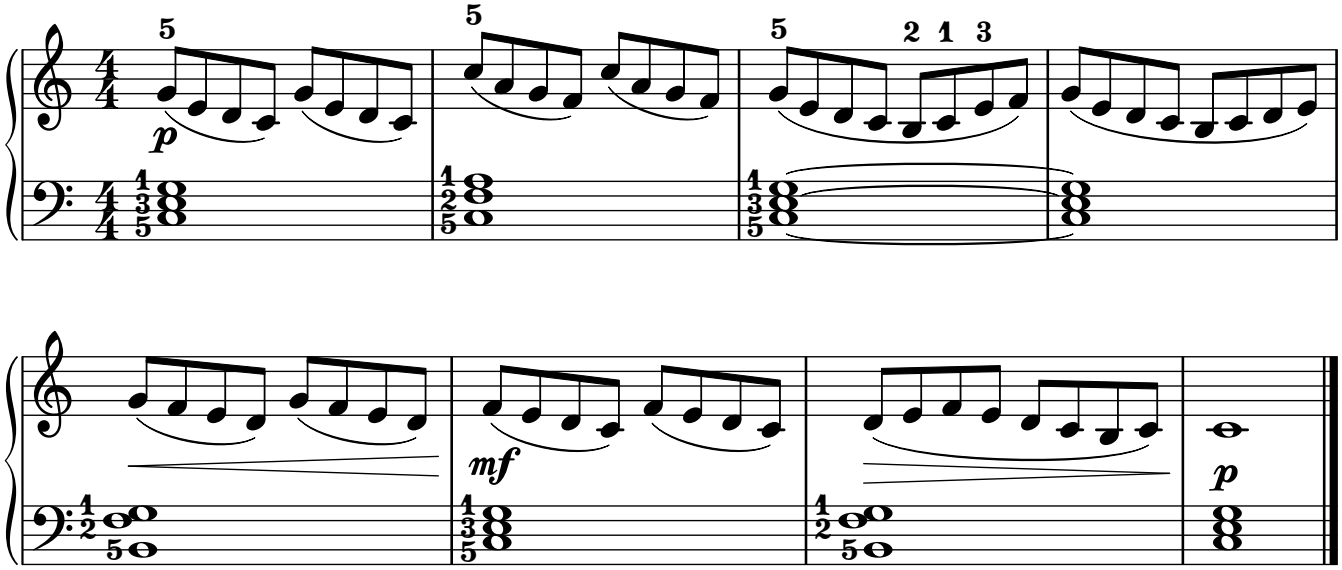
Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

La Candeur ♩ = 88

Friedrich Burgmüller, Op. 100 No. 1 (opening) - simplified
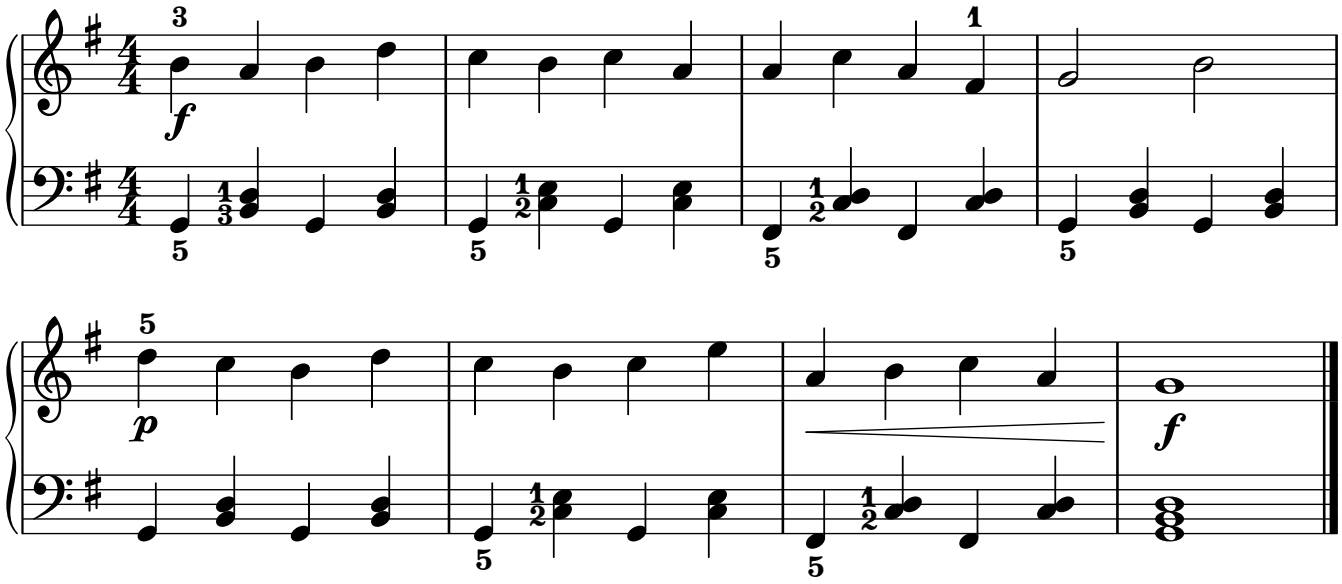
'Candour' (honesty) from Burgmüller's 25 Easy Studies. The left hand holds the chords exactly as Burgmüller wrote them; the right hand is an octave lower than written, and the last two bars are simplified so the piece ends at home. Source: Mutopia Project no. 202.



Oom-pah March ♩ = 96

Original
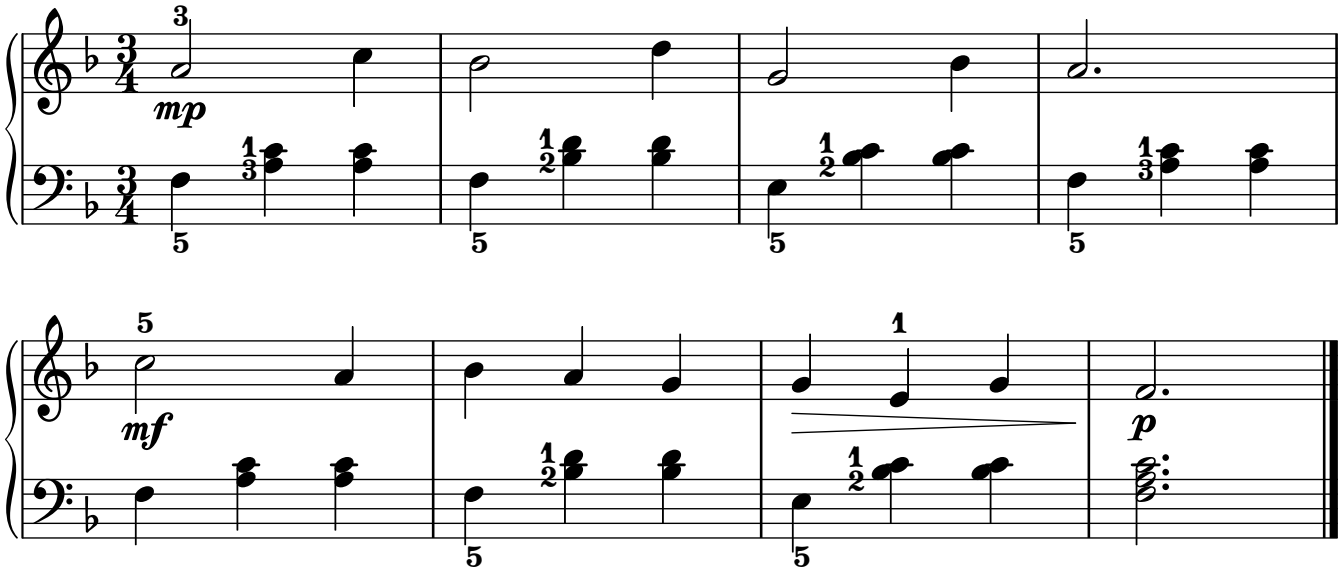
A march over an oom-pah bass in G major. In bars 3 and 7 the left hand's V7 shape has F-sharp at the bottom; in bar 3 the right-hand thumb stretches down to F-sharp too.



Ballroom Waltz ♩ = 120

Original

Oom-pah-pah in F major. The IV shape (F, B-flat, D) and the V7 shape (E, B-flat, C) both have B-flat in the middle.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 2?

- Play five new Part B to D exercises at the speeds shown: at most one stop each, 9 notes out of 10 right.
- Every left-hand chord sounds together, and you can name it (I, IV or V7) from its shape.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 2.